



Economics

China Macro

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Surge in imports should lead to further RMB strength

We are revising our view on the RMB, now expecting stronger appreciation this year, owing to China's very strong imports since the beginning of the year. History and our analysis suggest that a surge in China's imports of upstream products will likely be followed by a further pickup in export orders, or a recovery of domestic demand, or both. In any case, this will likely lead to a stronger RMB down the road. Our new baseline forecast is that RMB will appreciate to 6.55/USD by end-2026 and 6.3/USD by end-2027.

A surge in imports reduced China's trade surplus

China's exports have been strong so far this year and will likely continue... We've written a few notes, exploring the multiple drivers ("[AHEAD](#)": AI, HALO, Energy, Accelerating green transition and Diversification) and explaining why this high exports growth will likely be sustained.

...but it has not led to higher trade surpluses so far, owing to even faster growth in imports. Exports have been remarkably strong since the beginning of the year, growing by 15% YoY in the first four months. But equally remarkable was the surge in imports, which grew even faster 23% YoY in USD terms in January-April, outpacing exports by 8 full percentage points. As a result, China's trade surplus dropped to 1.4% of GDP in the first 4 months, 0.2ppt lower than same period last year.

The high import growth in the first four months can be attributed to (1) AI-related products such as chips, semiconductor equipment, and computers; **and (2) upstream manufacturing inputs** such as non-ferrous metals, chemical products, and machinery. Out of the USD 132bn increase in imports in Q1, about 40% is AI-related, while another 30% are traditional upstream inputs. Both point to a restocking of industrial inventory.

Meanwhile, oil prices' impact on imports appears to be limited. China's import growth was already strong in Jan-Feb before the Iran war. Crude oil imports were flat YoY in the first four months, contributing little to overall import growth. As oil import prices surged 40% YoY in April, import volume dropped 20% YoY, partially offsetting the impact on imports.

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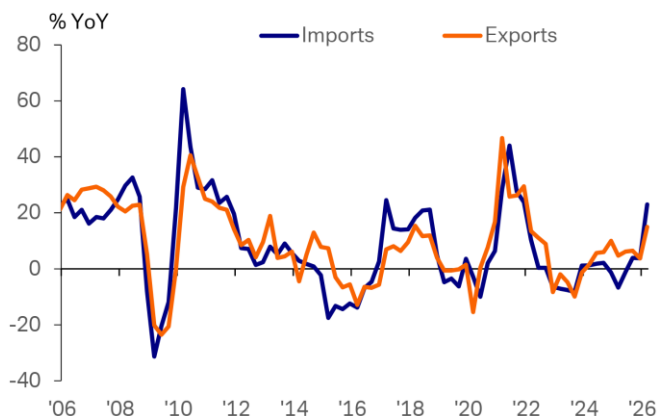
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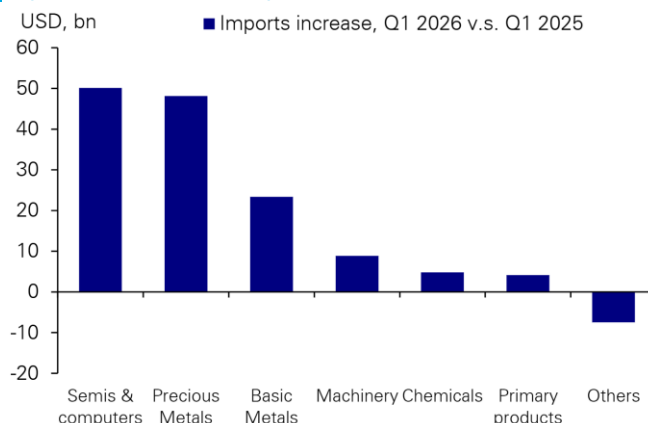


Figure 1: Imports growth exceeded exports in Q1 2026...



Source: Deutsche Bank Research

Figure 2: ...driven by imports of AI-related products and upstream industrial inputs



Source: Deutsche Bank Research

Why have imports surged? Two possibilities

Why are Chinese manufacturers suddenly importing more and re-stocking their inventory? History suggests two possible explanations. One possibility is that they are accumulating raw materials for future exports. The other possibility is that they are preparing for stronger domestic demand. These two explanations would imply different paths for future trade balance:

- **If imported materials are for future exports**, for example owing to global demand for AI data centers and EVs, then the natural next step is for exports growth to rise further. The difference between import and export growth will narrow, and **trade surplus will likely increase again**.
- **Alternatively, if domestic demand is the main driver for imports** (such as for domestic investment in AI and infrastructure projects), then import growth could continue to outpace export growth for a sustained period, and trade surplus will likely narrow further.

We tend to believe that both paths are at play simultaneously. On external demand side, AI demand and data-center investment are still accelerating globally, evidenced by strong semiconductor exports from neighboring economies. China's export-order PMI is also rising, all indicating strengthening external demand. On domestic demand side, China's fixed-asset investment has rebounded since year-beginning, manufacturing profits have recovered, and the real estate market has shown signs of stabilization, all creating conditions for domestic demand recovery.

RMB will have to strengthen, one way or another

Here comes the more interesting conclusion: **regardless of what is driving the imports surge, it will likely eventually lead to the same destination: further strength in the RMB.**

The rationale is simple as follows:

- If external demand is the main driver of recent imports, the narrowing trade surplus will only be transitory. China's trade surplus will likely widen again, resulting in increased exporter repatriation and a stronger RMB.



- If rapid imports growth is driven by domestic demand, then China's growth and inflation will likely pick up further. In that case, interest rates could not stay at today's near historically low levels. Monetary policy will shift, liquidity will tighten, and the interbank market will have to price in a stronger recovery, leading to RMB appreciation.

Recent history verifies this bullish RMB view. The situation where both imports and exports accelerate, but imports growing much faster than exports, has occurred twice in the past two decades, in 2010-11 and in 2017, respectively. Interestingly, the macroeconomic environment during both periods is also similar to today, namely PPI exiting deflation after a period of fiscal and monetary policy easing.

- **2010-11 was a scenario of resonating domestic and external demand.** Initially, high import growth benefited from China's stimulus plan. However, as the global economy recovered, export growth also accelerated, eventually surpassing import growth by H2 2010. PBOC's monetary policy response was relatively lagging, with its first interest-rate hike occurring in October 2010. **The RMB began to strengthen in mid-2010, appreciating for a total of 7.8% against the USD by the end of 2011.**
- **2017, on the other hand, was a story dominated by domestic demand.** Driven by expansion of local government finances and a rebound in the property sector. Throughout 2017, import growth consistently outpaced export growth, and trade surpluses continued to narrow. The PBOC's monetary policy shifted early, with several OMO rate hikes in the first half of 2017. **The RMB appreciated 6.7% against the USD in one year.**

Figure 3: 2026 compared to previous China imports surge episodes

	2010-11	2017	2026 (Jan-April)
Exports growth	26%	8%	15%
Imports growth	33%	16%	23%
10y CGB yield	3.6% => 3.5%	3.1% => 3.9%	1.8% => 1.8%
PPI Inflation, average	5.8%	6.3%	--
PPI turn positive	Nov-09	Sep-16	Mar-26
PBOC first rate hike	Oct-10	Jan-17	--
RMB appreciation against USD	7.8%	6.7%	2.8%

Source: Deutsche Bank Research

Our long-standing forecast that RMB will appreciate to 6.7/USD by end-2026 needs a revisit in light of our analysis above. **We revise up our RMB exchange rate forecast to 6.55/USD by end-2026.** This implies a 6.3% appreciation against USD and ~5% appreciation against the currency basket over 2026, making it one of the strongest years for RMB in the past two decades. Our end-2027 forecast remains 6.3/USD.

One more thing: a surge in gold imports. Customs data shows that China's imports of precious metals increased by 260% to reach USD 66 bn in Q1 2026,



contributing to one-third of the total import growth—a new trend we have not seen in China's recent history. Such a large increase in gold imports is unlikely to be for production or investment needs, but rather could be more related to consumption and savings. The implication of China's gold import growth for the RMB is not yet clear, but the implication for gold price is clear—please refer my DB colleagues' report [The return of history: gold, the dollar, and the monetary future](#), where they highlighted that EM countries' purchases of gold could be the main driver for gold prices going forward.



Appendix 1

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